

A Heap of Bones

Aṭṭhipuñjasutta (Iti 24)

Vuttañhetam bhagavatā vuttamarahatāti me sutam:

This was said by the Blessed One, said by the Arahant, as I have heard:

“Ekapuggalassa, bhikkhave, kappam sandhāvato saṃsarato siyā evam mahā aṭṭhikaṅkalo aṭṭhipuñjo aṭṭhirāsi yathāyaṃ vepullo pabbato, sace saṃhārako assa, sambhatañca na vinasseyyā”ti.

"Monks, if a single person were to wander and transmigrate on for an eon, he would leave behind a chain of bones, a pile of bones, a heap of bones, as large as this Mount Vepulla, if there were someone to collect them and the collection were not destroyed."

Etamattham bhagavā avoca. Tatthetam iti vuccati:

The Blessed One said this. In this connection, this was said:

“Ekassekena kappena, puggalassaṭṭhisañcayo; Siyā pabbatasamo rāsi, iti vuttam mahesinā.

"The accumulation of a single person's bones accumulated over the course of a single eon would be a heap equal to a mountain: so said the Great Seer.

So kho panāyaṃ akkhāto, vepullo pabbato mahā; Uttaro gijjhakūṭassa, magadhānaṃ giribbaje.

That great mountain is declared to be Mount Vepulla, north of Vulture's Peak, in the mountain ring of Magadha.

Yato ca ariyasaccāni, sammappaññāya passati; Dukkham dukkhasamuppādam, dukkhassa ca atikkamaṃ; Ariyañcaṭṭhaṅgikaṃ maggaṃ, dukkhūpasamagāminaṃ.

But when one sees the Noble Truths with right wisdom— suffering, the arising of suffering, the overcoming of suffering, and the Noble Eightfold Path leading to the calming of suffering—

Sa sattakkhattuṃ paramaṃ, sandhāvitvāna puggalo; Dukkhasantakaro hoti, sabbasaṃyojanakkhayā”ti.

Having wandered on at most seven times more, that person makes an end of suffering by destroying all fetters."

Ayampi attho vutto bhagavatā, iti me sutanti.

Catuttham.

This matter too was spoken by the Blessed One, as I have heard.

(Fourth)

Glossary

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
saṃsāra	saṃsāra	cycle of rebirth	A Heap of Bones	The beginningless round of birth, death, and rebirth, driven by craving and ignorance.
kappa	kappa	eon; cosmic cycle	A Heap of Bones	An inconceivably long period of time representing a cycle of the lifespan of a world system.
paññā	paññā	wisdom; experiential insight	A Heap of Bones	The experiential wisdom developed by observing the reality of things as they are, especially impermanence (<i>anicca</i>).

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
magga	magga	path; way	A Heap of Bones	The Noble Eightfold Path, which is the practical way leading to the complete eradication of suffering.
saṃyojana	saṃyojana	fetters	A Heap of Bones	The ten mental chains that bind a being to saṃsāra, completely eradicated at the stage of an arahant.
ariyasacca	ariyasacca	Noble Truth	A Heap of Bones	The four fundamental truths realized by noble ones, showing the nature of suffering and the path to its cessation.

Translator Notes

1. **The Magnitude of Saṃsāra:** The simile of the mountain of bones is one of the most vivid illustrations of the beginningless nature of *saṃsāra*. It is intended to evoke a sense of urgency (*saṃvega*) in the practitioner to work diligently toward liberation rather than wasting lifetimes in reaction to transient pleasures.
2. **Mount Vepulla:** Located near Rājagaha (the capital of Magadha), Mount Vepulla was a prominent local landmark. The Buddha uses this physical mountain, visible to his audience, to make the abstract duration of an eon (*kappa*) visually and emotionally tangible.

3. **The Limit of Seven Rebirths:** The verse refers to the "stream-enterer" (*sotāpanna*), a noble disciple (*ariya*) who has gained the first glimpse of *nibbāna*. Through the destruction of the first three fetters (*saṃyojana*), they are guaranteed to attain full liberation within at most seven more lifetimes.